Akbar may not have found one true God, but he had found his way.[13]

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When Akbar took the throne in 1556, writes Stephen Dale, he ‘reigned over, but did not rule, a modest, insecure north Indian state’. It was hardly a few cities – Lahore, Sirhind, Delhi and Agra, and a narrow corridor of land between them. A half-century later, when Akbar died, ‘his conquests and institutional innovations [had] bequeathed to his successors a stable, populous empire, whose wealth dwarfed that of his Safavid and Ottoman contemporaries’.[14]

The Mughal realm stretched far in space, from Kabul and Kashmir to Burhanpur, from Surat and Sindh to Orissa – and it was the rare foreign court where the wealth and power of the ‘Great Mogor’ was unknown – but it stretched even farther in time. Two and a half centuries after Akbar’s death, in 1857, it was the truncated Mughal court in Delhi that remained the greatest symbolic threat to the British Raj; and today, it is the Mughals, still, who arouse most envy and spleen amongst votaries of the Hindu Rashtra.

What gave the empire such longevity, such seemingly eternal relevance? Akbar, despite his best efforts, is long gone, along with his dynasty; their appearance in textbooks is being curtailed, the naming of roads after them is contested. But the *Akbarnama* remains.

As those cries of ‘bravo’ and ‘boo’ rang out, a sympathetic critic came to Abul Fazl and asked him what the point was of writing such a book. ‘Why do you take such pains, and why do you write in such a style? Will one out of thousands come into existence who will read this glorious volume aright, and be instructed by the new magic of its method? From whom do you expect the effectual recognition of the Truth?’ His friend advised the historian to write for a wider market.

As is often the case with writers, Abul Fazl was pleased by the praise but unimpressed by the advice. He was writing for a special audience, for the ‘Unique One of Time’. ‘What have I to do with a crowd?’[15]

A great deal, as it happens.

It is Abul Fazl whom Harbans Mukhia credits with ‘the construction of “harmony” as the encompassing ideological frame that would remain the